

Sleep Hygiene Handout

Daily habits that support healthy sleep, forming the foundation of insomnia treatment alongside CBT-I.

How to Improve Sleep Hygiene

- Keep a consistent sleep-wake schedule: Go to bed and wake up at the same time every day, including on weekends, to stabilize your body's internal clock.
- Cut caffeine in the afternoon and evening: Avoid caffeine, especially from mid-afternoon onward, since it can remain in the body for hours and interfere with sleep onset.
- Limit alcohol: Alcohol may feel sedating initially but disrupts sleep architecture later in the night, leading to lighter, more fragmented sleep.
- Avoid daytime naps if they worsen your nighttime sleep: If napping is reducing your natural sleep drive at night, skip it or limit it to a short nap earlier in the day.
- Reserve the bedroom for sleep only: Avoid working or using screens in bed, so your brain associates the bedroom specifically with sleep rather than wakeful activity.
- Get out of bed if you can't sleep after about 20 minutes: Lying awake and frustrated reinforces the bed as a place of wakefulness. Get up, do something calming in dim light, and return when sleepy.
- Get daytime physical activity and natural light: Regular exercise and morning light exposure help reinforce a healthy circadian rhythm and strengthen nighttime sleep drive.
- Wind down before bed: Keep a calming pre-sleep routine and avoid bright screens in the hour before bed, since blue light can delay the body's natural melatonin release.

When to seek urgent help

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suggestive of a co-occurring sleep disorder like severe sleep apnea — choking or gasping during sleep, or severe daytime sleepiness affecting safety, such as while driving.

This material is for patient and family education only and does not replace individualized medical advice. For a personal diagnosis or treatment plan, consult Dr. Kushal Kharel or a qualified mental health professional.

Dr. Kushal Kharel, MD Psychiatry — Consultant Psychiatrist, Kathmandu, Nepal

Phone: +977 9861800547 · drkushalkharel@gmail.com · drkushalkharel.com.np

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